MA THESIS PROTOCOL 2026–2027
Asian Studies Program

Leiden University · Faculty of Humanities

This document is adapted from the MA Asian Studies Thesis Protocol 2026–2027 for student reference. Some content intended for lecturers and supervisors has been removed. For the most current information, always consult your supervisor and check the MAAS prospectus and Brightspace.

Assignment of a Supervisor

New students in the MA60 and MA120 submit a thesis distribution form shortly after the start of the program, in September. The form names potential supervisors and describes your research interests. By mid-October, you are told which supervisor has been appointed.

It is your responsibility to contact your supervisor to set up a first meeting, and to come prepared to the meetings that follow.

Thesis Proposal

The thesis proposal is a required element of the course *Asian Studies: Perspectives and Debates*. The course grade is issued only once you have passed the exams and submitted the proposal. If you do not complete all elements of the course, including the proposal, within the academic year, you must repeat the course the following year.

The proposal should:

- state the topic and a research question;
- explain why the question matters in the field and how the project relates to the existing literature;
- describe the materials or sources you will analyze and your method;
- be no longer than **1,500 words**, excluding bibliography.

Submit the proposal to your supervisor by **December 14, 2026**. Your supervisor gives written feedback by the second week of January. Email the final version to your supervisor by **January 22, 2027**.

Thesis Supervision

You can meet your supervisor at least four times:

- **First meeting (October–November):** your topic, research question, and the theoretical and methodological approaches you want to explore, in preparation for the proposal. Your thesis must fall within your supervisor's area of expertise.

- **Second meeting (February):** the chapter outline and next steps, including the literature review.
- **Third meeting (March–April):** draft chapters, the literature review, the method of analysis, and the final structure of the thesis.
- **Final meeting:** feedback on your thesis draft, including its structure and conclusion.

Submit a draft of your thesis by **May 1, 2027**, ideally the whole thesis. Your supervisor gives written feedback within 10 working days and holds a final meeting with you. **If you submit no draft by May 1, you lose the right to further feedback and may not be allowed to submit a final version on June 15.**

Use the **MAAS thesis progress overview and checklist 2026–2027**, available on Brightspace, to track your progress and to check the title page requirements.

Thesis Submission

Email the final version of the thesis as a PDF to your supervisor, with your second reader and mathesis@hum.leidenuniv.nl in CC, on or before **June 15, 2027**. Name the file with your student number and surname (for example, `s1234567surname.pdf`).

The thesis file must include the **AI disclosure statement** (available on Brightspace), placed after the title page.

Any extension to the deadlines must be approved by the Board of Examiners. Supervisors cannot grant extensions.

Your supervisor and second reader have four weeks from submission to complete and register the assessment, that is, by **July 13, 2027**. For a resit submitted between July 1 and August 31, the period is six weeks.

Summary of Student Deadlines

Milestone	Date
Thesis proposal	December 14, 2026
Thesis proposal, final version	January 22, 2027
Thesis draft	May 1, 2027
Thesis final version	**June 15, 2027**
Resit (after a failing grade)	August 15, 2027
Fall resubmission: thesis draft	November 1
Fall resubmission: final version	December 15

Thesis Second Attempt

Students who do not pass the first assessment, or who do not complete the thesis by the final deadline, may resubmit under the guidance of the same supervisor, either by the resit deadline of August 15 or in the fall resubmission round (draft November 1, final version December 15).

Thesis Requirements and Format

The thesis should be **between 12,000 and 15,000 words**, excluding footnotes, references, and appendices.

You should use an established reference format according to the standards of the discipline (see, for example, *Journal of Asian Studies* for social science or *The American Historical Review* for history). Use that format **consistently and correctly** throughout the thesis.

There is no single standard format for the layout (font, font size, margins, spacing, footnotes or endnotes, etc.), so please consult your supervisor about their preference.

Assessment Criteria

Your thesis is assessed by your supervisor (first reader) and a second reader. The assessment is based on the following criteria:

Knowledge and Insight

The research question is based on a problem that reflects insight into the key discussions and methods of the field. Assessment also considers whether the problem is clear, relevant, well defined, placed in the existing literature, and original.

Application of Knowledge and Insight

The thesis critically analyzes primary material and sources. It should put complex concepts into practice, use effective research methods, and draw on secondary sources meant for an advanced academic audience. It should also describe and justify the adopted method and apply knowledge and insight in broader or multidisciplinary contexts.

Reaching Conclusions

Assessment considers logical and consistent reasoning, well-founded conclusions, and the degree to which the thesis question is answered. It also considers connections to other and future research, attention to social and ethical aspects, and critical reflection on one's role as researcher.

Communication

Assessment considers language use, including linguistic competence, readability, style, spelling, grammar, and the use and explanation of correct terminology. It also considers the structure and layout of the thesis, as well as the apparatus, including annotations, correct use of reference guidelines, completeness of references, and bibliography.

Learning Skills (Process)

Assessment considers the degree of independence, planning and time management, handling of supervisor feedback, and, if applicable, participation in a thesis group.

Specialization Requirements

In addition to the general criteria, your thesis must meet the requirements of your specialization.

MA60 East Asian Studies: Broad knowledge of East Asia. Knowledge of the history, development, and current trends in East Asian Studies. The ability to locate, assess, and use original sources in modern or classical Chinese, modern or classical Japanese, or modern or classical Korean.

MA60 South Asian Studies: Broad knowledge of South Asia. Knowledge of the history, development, and current trends in South Asian Studies. For students who have completed intermediate or advanced language electives, the ability to use original sources in Hindi, Sanskrit, or Classical Tibetan.

MA60 Southeast Asian Studies: Broad knowledge of Southeast Asia. Knowledge of the history, development, and current trends in Southeast Asian Studies. For students who have completed intermediate or advanced language electives, the ability to use original sources in Malay/Indonesian.

MA60 History, Arts and Culture (students who entered before September 2026)**:** Broad knowledge of one or more regions in Asia. Knowledge of history, development, and current trends in the study of the history, art, or culture of these regions. Familiarity with disciplinary theories and methods associated with the study of history, arts, and/or culture.

MA60 Politics, Society, and Economy (students who entered before September 2026)**:** Broad knowledge of one or more regions in Asia. Knowledge of history, development, and current trends in the study of the politics, society, or economy of these regions. Familiarity with disciplinary theories and methods associated with the study of politics, society, and/or economy.

MA60 Global Asian Studies: Broad knowledge of one or more regions in Asia, including their internal and external dynamics. Knowledge of history, development, and current trends in Asia, particularly the aspects that connect the region. Familiarity with disciplinary theories and methods for the study of Asia in the humanities and social sciences.

MA120 Chinese, Japanese, Korean Studies: Foundational knowledge of the history and development of Asian Studies. Knowledge of research in social sciences and humanities disciplines grounded in Asian Studies. Understanding of the concepts, terminology, and approaches relevant to the regional and disciplinary specialization. Knowledge of the main research methods and techniques and their application. Skills in locating, retrieving, assessing, and using sources and specialist secondary literature for original research. The ability to independently design, conduct, and complete original research. Excellent command of Chinese, Japanese, or Korean that enables use of the language for academic and professional purposes.